

The Hansen and Jensen families' Danish-American journey from Jutland to Minnesota

The story of the Hansen and Jensen families represents a compelling chapter in the larger narrative of Danish immigration to America during the 19th century. Between 1870 and 1930, over **300,000 Danes left their homeland for America**, [Wikipedia +2](#) with many settling in Minnesota's fertile farmlands.

[Archives](#) [Wikipedia](#) Your family's journey from Denmark's windswept coasts to the prairies of Freeborn County, Minnesota, exemplifies both the challenges and triumphs of this massive migration.

Hans Hansen's generation shaped Minnesota's Danish community

Hans Hansen (1835-1913), a blacksmith and poet, and his wife Bertha Marie (1839-) from Stanholt, Denmark, embodied the skilled craftsman class that formed the backbone of Danish emigration. Born during Denmark's population explosion—when the country grew from 900,000 to 2.5 million people between 1800 and 1910—[Every Culture](#) [Ancestry](#) Hans came of age in an era when **Danish blacksmiths could earn 4-5 times more in America** [LOC](#) than in their homeland. [Wikipedia](#) The couple's remarkable feat of raising 13 children speaks to both the challenges and opportunities of immigrant life.

While Hans Hansen's specific poetry and composition books haven't been located in online archives, the tradition of Danish craftsmen maintaining literary pursuits was well-documented. Denmark's rich poetic heritage, spanning from medieval ballads through the Golden Age (1800-1850), [Wikipedia](#) traveled with immigrants who preserved their cultural identity through written works. [Amazon](#) [Blogger](#) The **Museum of Danish America in Elk Horn, Iowa**, [Danishmuseum](#) and the **Danish American Archive and Library in Blair, Nebraska**, [Danishmuseum](#) maintain extensive collections of such immigrant writings, suggesting potential repositories for Hans's creative works. [Danishmuseum](#)

The timing of the Hansen family's immigration aligns perfectly with Danish emigration's peak years. In 1882 alone, **11,618 Danes entered America**, [Wikipedia](#) [Ancestry](#) driven by economic pressures, land inequality, and the devastating loss of 40% of Denmark's territory to Germany in the 1864 war. [Wikipedia](#) During the 1870s, almost half of Danish immigrants traveled in family groups like the Hansens, though this percentage would drop to just 25% by the 1890s. [Every Culture](#) [Wikipedia](#)

Charles C. Hansen bridged two worlds in Albert Lea

Charles C. Hansen (Carl Christian, 1867-1947), arriving in America at just six months old, represents the generation that grew up straddling Danish heritage and American opportunity. His birthplace, listed as "Baskjers, Denmark," presents an intriguing mystery—no Danish town by this name exists in genealogical records, suggesting either a transcription error from handwritten documents or an anglicization of a

Danish place name. This challenge exemplifies the difficulties many researchers face when tracing Danish roots, where names like Bagsværd or other phonetically similar locations might have been misrecorded.

His 1888 marriage to Inger Marie Jensen united two prominent Danish families in Freeborn County. Charles's service as treasurer of the Danish-Norwegian Baptist Church for 16 years demonstrates the unique religious landscape of Minnesota's Danish community. The **First Danish-Norwegian Baptist Church of Albert Lea**, founded February 14, 1874, grew from 12 charter members to 66 within five years, [\(Albert Lea Tribune\)](#) reflecting the rapid growth of Danish settlement in the area.

The couple's 50th wedding anniversary celebration at the Hotel Albert in 1938 marks a significant milestone in Albert Lea's social history. The hotel, located at the corner of South Broadway Avenue and College Street, operated its famous Spanish Dining Room for over 35 years before its demolition in the mid-1970s. The tragedy of losing two sons—Henry Guy Hansen at age 22 in 1900 and Earl Elmer Hansen as an infant in 1897—reflects the harsh realities of life in this era, when childhood mortality rates remained devastatingly high.

The Jensens brought Danish craftsmanship to Clarks Grove

Soren Jensen's journey from Sæby in Jutland to Clarks Grove, Minnesota, represents the skilled artisan migration that enriched American communities. **Sæby, a coastal town in northern Denmark's Hjørring County**, had been a commercial center since receiving market rights in 1524. Parish records from Sæby City Parish, available from 1814-1892, document the community from which the Jensens departed.

As a carpenter who crafted household items, Soren Jensen continued Denmark's renowned woodworking traditions in America. Danish furniture makers of the 19th century were celebrated for pieces where "function determined form," a philosophy that would later influence modern design movements.

[\(Family Tree Magazine\)](#) The Danish guild system had maintained these high standards for centuries, and immigrant craftsmen like Jensen brought this expertise to frontier communities.

The Jensen family's settlement near Clarks Grove placed them at the heart of Minnesota's most significant Danish agricultural innovation. In 1890, Danish immigrants established the **Clarks Grove Cooperative Creamery, the first successful cooperative creamery in Minnesota**. [\(Genealogy Trails\)](#) [\(Wikipedia\)](#) This revolutionary institution, sparked by Hans Peter Jensen's 1884 visit to Denmark to learn about new cream separator technology, [\(MNopedia\)](#) became the model for over 550 cooperative creameries statewide by 1900. [\(MNopedia\)](#)

Danish place names reveal immigration's complex geography

The challenge in verifying several Danish place names—Stanholt, Baskjers, Helland, and Hiesalt—illustrates common genealogical obstacles. None of these names appear in Danish genealogical databases or historical gazetteers, suggesting several possibilities: phonetic spellings recorded by English-

speaking officials, farm names rather than town names, or locations from Denmark's lost territories in Schleswig-Holstein. Danish letters like å, ø, and æ were often transcribed incorrectly, and the suffix "-holt" (meaning "wood" in Danish) suggests authentic Danish origins despite verification challenges.

Denmark's administrative structure in the 1800s consisted of 24 counties (amt), divided into districts (herred) and parishes (sogn). [FamilySearch](#) The **Danish National Archives (Rigsarkivet)** maintains parish registers from the 1600s onward, now digitized and accessible through Arkivalieronline. [Danishheritage +3](#) These records, including births, marriages, deaths, and confirmations from 1736, provide the foundation for Danish genealogical research. [Family Tree Magazine](#) [FamilySearch](#)

Freeborn County became a Danish-American cultural crossroads

The Danish settlement of Freeborn County represents a unique chapter in American immigration history. By the 2000 census, **5.8% of Freeborn County's population claimed Danish ancestry**, [Wikipedia](#) testament to the lasting impact of 19th-century immigration. The county's Danish communities developed differently from the larger Scandinavian settlements, with Danish immigrants assimilating more rapidly than their Norwegian and Swedish counterparts [Wikipedia](#) while maintaining distinct cultural contributions. [Archives](#) [Wikipedia](#)

Clarks Grove, laid out in 1890 but with a post office established in 1857, [Genealogy Trails](#) [Wikipedia](#) became synonymous with Danish agricultural innovation. The community was sometimes called Kanalerup or Kanolerup, reflecting its Danish heritage. [Albert Lea Tribune](#) The **First Danish Baptist Church**, organized in 1863—before the village itself was founded—celebrated its 60th anniversary in 1923, [Genealogy Trails](#) [FamilySearch Digital Library](#) demonstrating the primacy of religious community in immigrant life.

Albert Lea's development as the county seat in 1857 [Genealogy Trails](#) provided commercial and administrative opportunities that attracted Danish families. The city's Danish community maintained close ties with Clarks Grove, creating a network of kinship and commerce that sustained both communities. The Danish-Norwegian Baptist churches in both towns reflected Minnesota's unique multi-ethnic Scandinavian character, where national groups that rarely mixed in Europe created new hybrid institutions in America.

Family dispersal followed classic Danish-American patterns

The migration of Hansen children to California, Chicago, and Washington state exemplifies typical Danish-American mobility patterns. After initial settlement in the Midwest, second-generation Danish-Americans often pursued opportunities in rapidly growing western cities and states. **Chicago alone had over 10,000 first-generation Danes by 1900**, [Every Culture](#) making it a major urban center for Danish culture. California and Washington attracted Danish families seeking milder climates and new economic opportunities in logging, fishing, and agriculture. [Archives](#)

This dispersal pattern reflects Danish immigrants' relatively quick assimilation into American society.

[Wikipedia](#) Unlike some immigrant groups that maintained isolated ethnic enclaves for generations, Danes were more readily accepted due to their Northern European, Protestant background and rapid English language acquisition. [Archives +2](#) The trade-off between cultural preservation and economic advancement created tensions within Danish-American communities, exemplified by the split between "Happy Danes" who emphasized cultural preservation and "Holy Danes" who advocated complete assimilation.

[Danishmuseum +2](#)

Preserving Danish-American heritage requires multiple research strategies

The comprehensive family history you seek exists across multiple archives and databases. The **Museum of Danish America's Genealogy Center** in Elk Horn, Iowa, maintains over 35,000 artifacts and offers professional research services. [Danishmuseum](#) [LibraryThing](#) Danish-American newspapers like **Den danske Pioneer** (1872-1950s) and **Bien** (1882-2018) published obituaries, social news, and community announcements that often provide crucial genealogical details. [Wikipedia](#)

For continuing research, several pathways prove most promising. The **Danish Emigration Archives (Udvandrerarkivet)** in Aalborg holds comprehensive records from 1869-1940, including Copenhagen emigration records and passenger lists. [Danishheritage +2](#) FamilySearch and Ancestry.com maintain extensive Danish parish records, census data, and immigration documents. [LOC +3](#) The **National Danish-American Genealogical Society**, affiliated with the Minnesota Genealogical Society, provides expert guidance for researchers navigating Danish records. [Danishgenealogy](#)

Local resources in Freeborn County offer additional opportunities. The county maintains vital records from 1870 for births and deaths, and from 1857 for marriages. [FamilySearch](#) Cemetery records through Find A Grave and local cemetery associations document burial locations and family connections.

[Danishmuseum](#) The Minnesota Historical Society holds manuscript biography collections and Alien Registration Records from 1918 [FamilySearch](#) that often contain valuable genealogical information. [LOC](#)

[FamilySearch](#)

Conclusion

The Hansen and Jensen families' journey from Denmark to Minnesota represents thousands of similar stories that shaped America's agricultural heartland. From Hans Hansen's dual identity as blacksmith and poet to the innovative cooperative creamery at Clarks Grove, Danish immigrants brought skills, traditions, and organizational methods that fundamentally transformed their adopted communities. While specific documents and records remain elusive in online sources, the extensive archival infrastructure—from Danish parish registers to Minnesota county records—provides clear pathways for uncovering the detailed family history you seek.

The challenge of verifying Danish place names and locating specific family records reflects broader patterns in immigration history, where names changed, records were lost, and stories evolved across generations. Yet the strength of Danish record-keeping traditions, both in Denmark and Danish-American communities, means that patient research through appropriate archives will likely yield the specific documentation of Hans Hansen's poetry, the Jensen family connections, and the individual stories that bring this remarkable family history to life. [Archives](#) The Danish-American experience in Freeborn County stands as testament to how immigrant communities simultaneously preserved their heritage while building distinctly American institutions that continue to shape Minnesota's cultural and economic landscape today.